

Rats! Yet another climate change challenge

Global warming helps rodent populations thrive in many cities, researchers find.

By Karen Kaplan

If scorching heat waves, destructive storms, prolonged droughts and rising seas aren't enough to make some folks fear the consequences of climate change, perhaps this will do the trick: The warmer it gets, the faster rats multiply in cities that already struggle to contain them.

That is sure to be unwelcome news to Americans, who collectively endure well over \$27 billion worth of property damage each year at the hands — and teeth — of rats. That doesn't include the cost of the diseases the animals spread, such as hantavirus, murine typhus and bubonic plague, nor the mental health toll of living among them.

The new findings, reported recently in the journal Science Advances, are based on records of rat sightings in 16 cities around the world. Unfortunately for humans, 11 of those cities saw their rat populations expand over the course of the study, while two cities held steady and only three achieved measurable declines.

That the rodents are thriving should come as little surprise. They're perfectly suited to urban environments, where they make their homes in walls, basements and subway stations and feast on garbage, sewage, dog poop and abandoned pizza slices. The only continent they have yet to conquer is Antarctica.

"This species is really well-adapted to take food and convert that into new baby rats that are scampering around your neighborhood," said Jonathan Richardson, a biologist at the University of Richmond in Virginia who studies wildlife in cities and their impact on human health. "They do that really efficiently."

One of the few things that slows rats down is cold weather. And with climate change, we have less of it. [See Rats, A8]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

OFFICIALS say risks would be much higher if ash and other hazards are not cleared quickly from residential areas like Pacific Palisades.

Concern rises over debris disposal

Southland facilities not designed for hazardous material are to receive contaminated ash

By Tony Briscoe

Despite repeatedly warning that wildfire debris likely contains hazardous substances, public officials are preparing to dump millions of tons of contaminated ash and rubble from the Eaton and Palisades fires into Southern California landfills that were not designed to handle high concentrations of toxic chemicals.

For weeks, Los Angeles

County leaders have urged residents to avoid wildfire ash. Public health officials have said they suspect the debris is teeming with brain-damaging heavy metals and cancer-causing chemicals from thousands of incinerated homes and cars.

Ordinarily, when these toxic chemicals are found at high levels in solid waste, they would be disposed of at hazardous waste landfills — typically located far from densely populated areas and

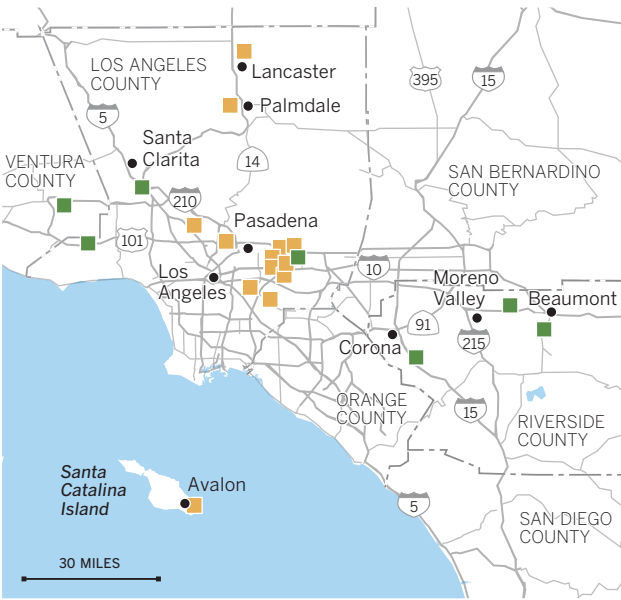
specifically engineered with environmental protections to prevent leakage that might affect nearby residents.

However, every year when disasters strike California, a series of emergency waivers and disaster exemptions allow for potentially contaminated debris — including wildfire ash — to be treated as nonhazardous waste and taken to landfills that typically handle only [See Toxic, A10]

Moving wildfire waste to landfills

Toxic ash and rubble from the recent wildfires is expected to be taken to nonhazardous waste landfills across Southern California. At least five landfills have taken steps to accept this disaster debris.

- Accepts wildfire debris or has submitted application to accept wildfire debris
- Other landfills



Los Angeles County Department of Public Health, CalRecycle, OpenStreetMap
LORENA ELEBEE, TONY BRISCOE Los Angeles Times

Fire launched a desperate house hunt

When Altadena home burned, couple were thrust into competing with others displaced.

By Jack Flemming

As the flames plunged down Eaton Canyon on Jan. 7, Todd Smoyer fled his Altadena home in tears knowing it would be the last time he'd

see it.

His neighbor confirmed the next morning that the Midcentury ranch was a heap of ash.

The devastating news kicked off a manic January for Smoyer and his husband, who joined thousands of other desperate refugees scrambling for housing. Smoyer's quest for a long-term lease saw him claw his way across the region, darting from city to desert to

ocean and encountering a cast of characters with questionable motives along the way.

"It's been overwhelming," Smoyer said. "We haven't been able to relax for a month."

When tens of thousands of people evacuated from Pacific Palisades and Altadena, demand for hotels and short-term rentals skyrocketed. But Smoyer and his [See House hunt, A10]

COLUMN ONE

Say what? In S. Korea, a different sort of term limits

The government is fighting to keep English 'loanwords' from diluting the language

By Max Kim
REPORTING FROM SEOUL

Kim Hyeong-bae, a South Korean linguist, had a problem: how to translate the word "deepfake" into Korean.

A senior researcher at the National Institute of Korean Language, a government regulator, Kim works in the public language department. His job is to sift through the many foreign words that clutter everyday speech and bring them to the committee — called the "new language group" — to be translated into Korean.

"Deepfake," which is pronounced *dihp-PAY-kuh* and has been appearing in newspaper headlines with increasing frequency, was a textbook candidate.

A word-for-word translation would sound like non- [See Words, A4]



Scan this code with your phone to hear the pronunciations of some of the new Korean words mentioned in this story.



JEAN CHUNG For The Times

PEDESTRIANS in Seoul walk past storefronts with English words in their signage. English is widely seen in South Korea as the language of cultural sophistication and a Western education.

Migrants held in federal prisons

Trump administration using facilities to detain some people arrested in immigration crackdown. **NATION, A5**

U.S. hiring cools during January

Job growth slowed as employers held back amid uncertainty over economy and Trump's policies. **BUSINESS, A7**

Mudslide risk on the horizon?

Forecasters say another Southland storm next week could be the strongest of the season. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 67/51. **B8**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

Printed with soy inks on partially recycled paper.



The day's top stories, at your fingertips.
Scan the code to download the app.

